A Nightmare In Cerulean

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A Nightmare In Cerulean

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Summary

Gabriel asks, “What do you think you’ll call yourself?”

“I don't know.” Emilie considers, the brooch pinned to her chest sparks casting blue flickers over her face, “when we were researching some of the legends referred to a Mayura. Turns out that's just the Sanskrit word for Peacock but I kind of like it. Do you have any ideas for your name?”

Chapter 1

“Hawk Moth.” He gasps at the long-lost voice echoing in his head, “I am Mayura. You're up against the wall, plagued by your deepest, darkest despair. Let me help you.”

No, he desperately thinks, *No not again.*

Nathalie *please,* he begs her. He can’t lose someone else to this, but the connection surges pulling the heaviness in his stomach out through his chest, “No, don't do that!”

“Let your despair be embodied in a powerful protection.”

Emilie runs her fingers over the brooch on her chest, “do you think it'll work?”

“I’d feel a little silly going all the way to Tibet and almost getting myself and Nathalie killed if it doesn’t, and all of this was just to get some jewellery.”

His wife sits down next to him, and puts her arm around her shoulders, “I’d never have abandoned you there Gabriel, remember that. If I’d to pull you out of that ice crevice myself, or remake the world with magic to save you I’d have done it.”

“I know you would have,” but still he doesn’t want to dwell on those moments there where he and Nathalie shivered alone in the cold and dark as their lives threatened to slip away, and changing the topic he asks, “what do you think you’ll call yourself?”

“I don't know.” Emilie considers, the brooch pinned to her chest sparks casting blue flickers over her face, “when we were researching some of the legends referred to a Mayura. Turns out that's just the Sanskrit word for Peacock but I kind of like it. Do you have any ideas for your name?”

Gabriel glances down to where the Butterfly Miraculous sits on his laptop. “Not really. By your naming standards I could just call myself The Butterfly I suppose.”

“Audrey would be appalled to see you so uncreative.”

He shrugs, “I doubt I'll get much use out of it. Yours seems more useful. I don't much like the idea of having to involve other people in our plans.”

“It's not like they’d *remember.* But you’re right. The Peacock is the prize. Having the Butterfly too is just the cherry on top.”

“Well,” the azure vision in front of him says, “what do you think?”

Gabriel casts his eyes over the perfectly fitting dress, the thigh skimming slit that sends heart racing, and up to the face framing fur.

“Stunning,” he says, “My dear Emilie,”

She lifts a hand up stopping him. “Mayura. You should call me Mauyra like this.”

“Wise,” he allows, it's certainly sensible to do all they can to hide their identities. Best not to have any suspicion fall on them.

Emilie twirls in excitement, sending her feathered skirt-train flying behind her.

“Oh darling,” she says, “you can't imagine how this feels.”

He smirks, as she falls out of her pirouette onto this chest, “it seems rather like that sort of power is intoxicating.”

Her pink eyes darken and for a moment she looks more like a bird of prey than the Peacock she's supposed to be.

Then it passes, and Gabriel just has his wife in his arms again as she trills, with her familiar laugh, “oh you can't imagine.”

The curl dangling over her cheekbone calls to him, and he gives in, coiling it round his ring finger. It’s beautiful, her hair like this, stylishly framing her face and adding a sense of era to the outfit.

Yet it's a surprise, Emilie has always loved her long hair, been so proud of its glossy sunray waves, he'd never have imagined her trading it in for a sleek dark bob like this.

“Have you been hiding a secret desire for short hair from me?” he mumbles.

“Isn't it better to look less like Emilie Agreste?”

“I suppose,” he should bear that in mind if he ever does transform himself though, “I’d have thought a mask would be easier.”

Mischief brims over in her grin, “do you really think I need one? Besides who would think a woman with no mask has anything to hide?”

Gabriel lets go and takes a step back, and considers her again.

Even knowing who she really is under that strange colouration, and with that bold make-up so different to Emilie’s naturalistic pastels, it’s almost impossible to recognise his wife in Mayura at all.

“Very clever,” he smirks back.

Emilie is... different as Mayura.

It makes sense he supposes, and she’s always had the most delightful talent for mimicry. Her impressions of Audrey and the self-centred people they’re forced to socialise with can make even him laugh.

It's why he’d believed wholeheartedly that she'd so obviously succeed as an actress. She’s never not put her all into the role she’s playing whether that's the loving daughter to the father she despises, or the faithful friend to the irritating women she cultivates for his sake, to ensure *Gabriel* is the brand mentioned over every coffee table that matters.

That her acting career never did take off he blames André for, because it’s easier than admitting that Emilie had put *his* career first instead of her own. Mustering all the charm Gabriel can only sustain in quick bursts. It's part of why he knew he had to give her the Miraculous the moment she mentioned them, to make things fairer.

People come away impressed with him. They come away delighted by Emilie.

The pool of niceness she manages to pull from, joking impressions aside, has always boggled him.

“Oh Gabriel,” Emilie would shake her head, “there’s no reason to be cruel.”

“Oh Gabriel,” Mayura smirks, without the slightest hesitance in her eyes, “we won't get what we want by being nice.”

Perhaps it's a release. A way for Emilie to let her cynical side show, a way to drop her constant pretence to the world. And yet, he has to reject that because that means Emilie is putting on a performance for *him.*

No. Mayura, with her sharp edges instead of Emilie’s warm softness, must be the act.

Playing the villain people call anyone who goes after power when they don’t understand.

He understands it better after she prompts him to put the other Miraculous on, despite his misgivings about how helpful it might be.

It’s…fun. *Freeing.* Fantastic.

Gabriel Agreste has boundaries, Gabriel Agreste has a reputation to maintain, Gabriel Agreste is restrained.

Hawk Moth is not.

Even the name should be ridiculous, and Gabriel's not quite sure where it came from, but Mayura accepts it with a short nod and satisfaction settling over her shoulders.

Transformed he dares to say the most ridiculous things, and not to worry about if some pun is actually good of not.

Emilie seems charmed by them.

He's even seen the Nathalie's mouth quirk up at the edge after one of them, a surprise from his stone-faced now-assistant who, save for that night in when they both thought they might die until Emilie brought salvation, keeps her feelings close to her chest.

Hawk Moth could feel them despite that if he wanted, but despite the fact he has very few morals when it comes to it Gabriel recoils from the idea. Nathalie's proved she can be trusted with their secrets. There's no reason to dive into the minutiae of how she feels about it. They need her loyalty and her skills. They don't need her to *like* every single part of it.

And anyway, he has no time to think about Nathalie any further when Mayura drags him down into a kiss. It's, oddly desperate actually, as if they'd been parted for months instead of waking up in the same bed this morning.

Nathalie's quiet excusing of herself barely permeates his brain, all his senses are consumed by *Mayura* and *blue* and she's clinging to him like she needs reassurance and who is Gabriel to deny that to her?

A tickling sensation wakes him up, and he opens his eyes to feather's caressing his face. Purple lips hover over his own.

Amusement dances in his wife's eyes.

He yawns, "Isn't it a little early to be Mayura?"

She tilts her head, "what's the time of day got to do with anything?"

I just want Emilie, he thinks, but he can see the fire in her eyes and he tries to placate her instead, "I'm just a little surprised."

"It's alright." She says, "I've dismissed the staff. We can't have them around while I'm doing my experiments anyway."

“You’ve,” but then she stops his objections with her mouth and he decides the discussion can wait a little later. He might prefer Emilie in his bed, but Mayura is wholly entrancing too.

“I hope Emilie hasn’t been too demanding?” He asks Nathalie when she picks him up at the airport after his trip to New York.

There’s an empty space at his side where his wife should be. Her rebuff of his offer to take him with him had thrown him. Usually he and Emilie stay as close together as possible, and it had felt especially odd with how she keeps trying to convince him to use his Miraculous despite there not yet being any need.

So far he’s generally resisted because *one of them* has to be focused on the rest of their lives but it does keep earning him a pout.

Nathalie’s mouth purses, “Mme. Agreste hasn’t asked for much at all monsieur.”

If his eyes could bore a hole in the car seat in front of them he would.

“Nathalie?”

Her eyes dart back to him in the rearview mirror, and there’s a pause, then she says, “It might be nothing.”

“It’s not nothing if you’re bringing it up.” It’s not quite a command but Nathalie flinches as if it is, which works because he’d meant it what way even.”

“She’s been…odd monsieur.”

“Odd?”

“You’ll see.”

He doesn’t see. Not until much later that night once he’s been quite thoroughly welcomed home when Emilie rolls over onto him and says, “I’ve been thinking.”

“Should I be frightened?”

“I don’t know.” She says, “you see, all our plans, all your success what’s the *point?”*

Gabriel hates that he's having this conversation without his glasses in the dark and he can barely make out her face, "The point? You?"

Emilie puts her finger over his lips stopping her, "I meant what's the point without someone to leave it to?"

Suddenly it's too warm in their room. Emilie's presence atop of him is smothering instead of comforting. *That was not in their plans.*

"You mean a child?"

"I do."

The silence after that is heavy in the room.

Emilie's breathe hitches, "you don't want one."

Instinctively he starts stroking the back of her head to sooth her, "Emilie I'm just shocked. I thought *you* didn't."

That's what she'd always said. That she didn't want a husband who would force her into that, that she was more than incubator, that the changes it would force on her body would terrify her, that she had reasons to believe it would be difficult anyway.

She'd told him that with her voice quivering like she'd been worried he'd break up with her for it. In truth Gabriel had been relieved. He'd never seen the appeal in the messiness and chaos of a child, and he'd never wanted to become his own father either.

But now his chest is wet with the tears silently dripping from her face.

"It's different now." She says.

"Why?"

"The Peacock Miraculous."

He stares at her outline in the dark, "you mean you want to *make* a child with the Miraculous."

"Just think," she says, "the perfect child and none of the danger of childbirth or ruin of my figure at all. We could choose every little bit about them, your eyes, my hair. Maybe your height but not until later. I don't want my little boy to overtake me too soon."

"Boy?"

"I'd prefer a boy I think. Easier. And," she shifts and kisses his forehead, "I know what you're afraid of, but you're *not* your father. And besides I'd be in control, there'd be no reason for you to get angry at him."

“I suppose,” it would make it easier certainly. That much is true, and to think no chance of anything going wrong, no genetic defects, an heir he could *design* from head to toe but, “if we made a child we’re have to keep him.” They couldn’t just create him and then dismiss him whenever they felt about it. That would be a *doll* not a child, and he is not pretending at being a father to a something as unreal as that.

“That’s kind of the point Gabriel.” Emilie says wryly.

He relaxes slightly at that, that Emilie understands the depth of what she’s proposing. That she actually does want a *child* strongly enough that having now been presented with a way around her own objections she’s jumping on it and that this isn’t some whim she’ll forget in the morning.

Still there’s the issue that, “you wouldn’t be able to create any other sentimonsters while he existed. Do you want a child,”

“A son,” she interjects.

“A son,” he accepts, “enough to give up on that ability?”

“Oh, don’t worry about *that.* I think I’ve found a way to get around it.”

“Really?”

“*Really,*” her hair tickles his cheek as her head moved, “each time I use that Miraculous I learn more and more.”

He thinks. It could be, *nice*, maybe. He hasn’t spoken to most of his own family since he left home, but a family of their *own,* of him and Emilie and their little boy perhaps that could be a totally different thing.

“We’d have to hide you not being pregnant”

“I’ll figure that out, Amélie’s husband has a place I could use.”

“And she’d help?”

“She’s my *sister.*”

It’s madness. And yet he doesn’t know how to refute it, “Let me think about it.”

He’s so focused on his work he doesn’t notice her stare on him. It’s not until Nathalie calls over with a question that he looks up and sees Mayura perched on the edge of his assistant’s desk.

Later Emilie whispers to him. “I’m deciding which of your emotions I want to create our child from.”

Despite his misgivings he finds himself sketching their hypothetical son. After all if the boy is under their control then Emilie’s *right,* there’s no reason Gabriel would ever want to use force against him. And perhaps with that fear allayed it wouldn’t be so hard to be a father after all.

Emilie leans against his shoulder once, “is that?”

“It is.”

She reaches out for the piece of paper, “he’s beautiful.”

“Perfect.” Gabriel agrees. He won’t settle for anything less. This is the most important design of his life. Other parents might get surprised by what traits show up in their child but not him and Emilie.

Emilie’s right. This will be far easier than a child made the traditional way would be. This will be fine.

“He should be a mix of us,” Emilie says, “my hair, your eyes. It would be such a pretty combination dark hair and,”

“Dark?”

Emilie blinks, “Blonde. I meant blonde. I’m sorry I don’t know.”

“Are you alright?” She doesn’t look it, “you look pale?”

“I feel faint.” She says.

“Here,” he scoops her up, “let’s get you to bed.”

“Thank you,” she whispers, and then, “Gabriel? What colour are my eyes?”

There’s a rock stuck somewhere below his collarbone, “green, your eyes are green.”

Emilie shakes terrified in his arms.

From then on in every sketch of their child at every possible age Gabriel gives him golden blonde hair and green eyes.

Just to remind his mother of her own.

It takes him far too long to work it out. He worries that Emilie's been taking something. He goes through her drawers behind her back, and when he can't find anything he asks Nathalie to look into if there's any history of mental illness in Emilie's family.

She agrees a little too eagerly and he wants to shake her and ask why she didn't say something more earlier but she's the only person he *can* talk about this to so he holds back a little longer.

Nothing of use comes out, although there is a worrying history of depression that vindicates her choice to create a son in a way where *they* can control the variables.

It's only when Nathalie makes some remark about Mayura's blue skintone being atypical for Miraculous wielders that it hits him how Emilie's got confused and then he feels like the worst husband in the world for not noticing and letting her waste so much of her time on the Miraculous instead of living.

Their plans can wait.

They'll have their son, and then they can take a break for a little and Emilie won't push herself into an exhaustion where half the time her eyes are *pink*.

Emilie is out at lunch with an heiress to a Japanese conglomerate she'd gone to school in Switzerland with. Gabriel has good hopes of things to come out of it both for their above-and-under board business practices.

Nathalie's swept the Atelier for bugs, and put the cameras covering the room onto a loop.

His assistant passes him a blown up photo of the Peacock Miraculous.

“Those scratches?” She says, “they’re not just from the wear and tear of time. I’ve been looking. Carefully like you asked me, when she couldn’t notice and only magic could have done it.”

Gabriel inhales as he takes the photograph, “Do you think it could harm Adrien?”

They’d only chosen their son’s name yesterday but it’s made him feel solid in a way that means foregoing creating him feels more like something more than that, like Emilie *is* already pregnant.

Nathalie sucks in a breath of her own, “I don’t know sir, but. I’ve not seen, and Mme. Agreste’s never mentioned any problems with any of her creations. The problems seem to be,”

“With her yes.” He almost tears the paper he’s pulling at it so hard, “what do you think it’s doing to her? Apart from her confusion.”

She looks honestly distressed in a way he’s never seen before when she says, “I don’t know.”

“Keep looking into it Nathalie. I’ll…have encourage her to use it less. After Adrien’s born.”

Chapter 2

Adrien is perfect.

Of course he is. That's how they made him.

A child isn't a dress or a handbag or a suit. It had been difficult for Gabriel to put away his sketches of their son despite Emilie's assurance he was perfect as he was. He'd been terrified there was some imperfection in his design, that he'd look at his son and realise in horror he could have done better.

As their baby curls his hand around his finger that all seems stupid, he can't see any way Adrien could possibly be improved.

Their son created by Emilie from Gabriel's love from her. His looks chosen for the most part by his father, his initial personality, though Emilie has warned him this will rely too on how they raise him, chosen for the most part by his mother. Both playing on their strengths.

A truly *human* creation from the Peacock Miraculous. Able to grow, to die, to have children of his own. Indistinguishable from any other person save for the method of his birth. A milestone in the history of the Miraculous.

Adrien yawns, blinking open his mother's eyes, and Gabriel feels a curl of unease in his stomach. Part of their son's appearance is because of his fears for Emilie rather than being chosen *for* Adrien's own sake. But then, as the baby looks at him with such trust, all his vaunted imagination can't visualise another appearance for Adrien.

The only flaw, perhaps, in Adrien's birth is that despite Mayura's voice in his mind as she brought their son into existence she had banished Gabriel to the other side of the door, while allowing *her* sister of all people in. Though he supposes it's not as if Amélie didn't already know what they were doing, with her help in hiding the pregnancy. The two of them has been cozened together for months while Emilie hid from the press.

Stage fright she'd maintained. And besides had Adrien's birth been *traditional* then Emilie would have had every right to exclude who she wanted from the birthing room, and apparently who she'd wanted was her twin.

Birth is a feminine matter he supposes. Even a magical one. And, "you can try arguing with a woman son, but you won't win. They're stubborn creatures." He mutters to his son.

Adrien takes this a cue to start crying.

Hopefully he's just hungry and that's not an omen for the future.

Gabriel wakes first to the sound of Adrien's crying. When he groans out of sleep, and rolls over he's annoyed to see Emilie still asleep. Technically either of them can feed the baby but seeing as Emilie's not working and he *is* she's supposed to deal with most of Adrien's needs. *Especially at night.*

Audrey's recommended a night nanny. Personally he thinks it's an excellent idea. Emilie though had blown up at him for it. Accusing him of outsourcing his own child, and claiming it would confuse Adrien and he wouldn't know who his mother was.

Adrien whines again, and the room flashes blue.

It takes a moment for his sleep-deprived brain to register that that's *not right.*

He sits up and looks down at his wife.

The Peacock Miraculous sits glowing in the divot of her chest. He rubs his eyes; he could swear there are more scratches than before.

Leaving Adrien to wail, even as he begins to scream, he reaches for the brooch pinned to her nightdress but Emilie's eyes fly open.

"What the *hell* are you doing?!" She says batting his hand away, "Adrien baby, mummy's here it's OK," she scoops up their baby from his crib, "don't worry about your father being mean and horrible and ignoring you, I'm here."

"His father wants to know why you're wearing that Miraculous."

Emilie gently bobs Adrien up and down, "I'm getting him a bottle."

"I want an answer. We agreed to put our plans aside, that *Adrien* was more important than risking him trying to find a way to create more sentimonsters. You said you wanted him to recognise you. How's he supposed to do that when you're blue half the time?"

Her eyes narrow, and Gabriel tries to remember if that's how she'd glared before Mayura, or if Emilie had just not got cross at him in the same way before. "I'm only wearing it."

"If you're not using it then *why* are you wearing it?" He spits back.

Her hold on Adrien tightens, making his previously diminishing cries louden again. Fury burns in her eyes, "Whoever wears this brooch has the power to take away our son's life. How on earth could you expect me to just leave it lying around?"

Then she stalks out of the room with those last words hanging in the air behind him chastising him for failing to properly protect his family.

He pinches at the bridge of his nose. He'll have to ask Nathalie to upgrade the security to the house. Emilie's right, the existence of the Miraculous *is* an unconsciousable risk to Adrien.

Nathalie's fairly undemanding as people go. It's part of why he'd been so keen to find a way to keep her on, after the purpose they'd hired her for, of finding the Miraculous had been completed.

He's no patience for people. But Nathalie, Nathalie's *easy.*

Right now though, he doesn't need any emotion-sensitive Miraculous to read the shock in her eyes, "Destroy the Peacock Miraculous?"

There's a not quite waver in her voice and he suddenly wonders what exactly *is* Nathalie's past. Antiquities and their acquisition. That much he knows but the question of *why* he has never worried about trusting her is suddenly a siren blaring in her head.

"Emilie brought it up." He says, and then as she stares at him white-faced something makes him say, "so long as the Peacock exists Adrien's not safe."

One of the many knots inside his chest unchurches as he says it. His instincts are always towards privacy but there is *something* in being able to talk about this to someone who isn't Emilie and her-

He swallows that voice.

Félix fills Gabriel with unease, for all his sister-in-law being pregnant at the same time Emilie "was" had seemed like a stroke of luck. Confusing the press as to which twin they were photographing.

The baby just looks *so like Adrien* but Adrien is couture and his cousin is just a random grab-bag of Amélie and her husband's genetics.

There's a reason that Adrien looks so like his mother. There's no reason Félix should look so little like his father.

Still all babies look much the same, and Adrien is undeniably cuter, Gabriel's sure the boys' appearances will look more disparate as they get older. For now he'll just have to ensure they're always dressed differently though generally he thinks it's obvious that the child he's holding right now isn't his son.

Adrien is a much more smiley baby funnily enough.

As if he hears Gabriel's thoughts Félix starts wailing, and when Gabriel automatically moves the baby to his shoulder the way he does with his son to comfort him, promptly pukes on him.

Yes. Adrien is definitely the superior cousin.

Emile sidles between him and his screen despite his best attempts to ignore her.

"Time for dinner, Gabriel." She smiles.

Emilie is his sun. He's caught in her gravity. But he does have a job to do. It's not like Emilie won't be here after, not like she shouldn't understand that, just like he's understood all her ideas, so it's easy to say, "I'm busy."

For a moment he swears her eyes flash pink, but then it's gone, and there's just Emilie's usual sunny smile, "No you're not."

"Work,"

"Can wait. I checked. And anyway I've a soireé coming up for people you need to meet."

Still there's, "Adrien,"

"Nathalie's watching him."

"*Nathalie?"*

His assistant is very capable, that's indisputably true, but Gabriel has never ever thought of her as *maternal* in any shape or form but then maybe that's her youth. Still the image is hard to reconcile. Dark serious Nathalie with his giggling sunshine son.

Emilie's face softens, "he's quite won her over you know. Adrien. At first she thought we were crazy,"

"*What?"* She'd never breathed a word of doubt to him.

"Yes, I can't blame her of course, and she made an admirable attempt to hide it but you could see it in her eyes, her wondering if I was infertile or something. I think she doubted if Adrien *was* truly human at first but now, like I said no one could be immune to that cute little face. She'd give her life for him now."

Gabriel feels oddly thrown by the idea, "She... would?"

There's the faintest crease between Emilie's brows then she's laughing again. "It's a good thing Gabriel."

Gabriel would never admit it, but he misses when Adrien had been a baby, interrupted sleep and all.

In fact from other people's envious responses it turns out Adrien had actually starting sleeping through the night remarkably early like the paragon he's supposed to be.

Only unfortunately *that* description doesn't feel like it relates to the toddler they have now.

It had been so *easy* to fulfill Adrien's needs back when all he'd wanted was to be fed, and changed, and carried. Gabriel had even worn him wrapped to his chest when Emilie had wanted to go out.

He'd been glad to see her take an interest in something over than their son and the Miraculous. Adrien has been good for his mother. In many ways Gabriel thinks he's saved her.

She still wears the Peacock every hour of the day. Even taking it into the bathroom with her when she showers. But, she doesn't seem to be *using* it. There's no confusion, or exhaustion like he'd almost not seen until too late before.

Nathalie will come through with how to destroy the damn thing and they'll be in the clear.

They're rich, and successful, and they have Adrien. Why reach further, to the sun like Icarus?

Though he wouldn't mind if Emilie could just make Adrien a little *quieter*. He'd hoped back when he'd allowed him into the Atelier as a baby that some of the artistic atmosphere would rub off.

Instead Adrien seems to have no inclination that way at all. Much more, as far as Gabriel can tell, interested in destroying whatever he can get his hands on than making anything.

He's had to take a lot of deep breaths, and curl his flickers of annoyance round into something measured and cold that can be expressed in a curt tone that doesn't effect a toddler.

Emilie keeps him out of the Atelier now.

Even watching out the window as Adrien runs round the garden on his chubby little legs with his mother chasing after him feels exhausting.

His ear piercing shriek, as she captures him lavishing with kisses, somehow makes it through the window.

Thank god Emilie is there to take care of Adrien. For both their sakes.

“It can't be done,” every single atom of him wants to crumble but he refuses to give in. To look like some sort of failure. Like the wimp his father had always accused him of being.

“No.” Nathalie says, “I think it can be. Not easily and there’s no records of successful attempts, though than it's not something many people would attempt.”

He supposes not. Hard to resist the lure of power offered by a Miraculous. Harder still to be so certain in that rejection as to have the thing destroyed entirely.

She continues, “the cataclysm of the Black Cat Miraculous boosted by an akumasation by the Butterfly. It *could* work.”

Gabriel’s never believed in fate. But it would be fitting if one half of the key to destroying the Miraculous that has such power over his family had been found with it.

“So what’s the problem?”

They found these two. They can find others.

“I can't be certain how it would effect Adrien.”

“I see.” He feels Nathalie’s gaze on him, as he joins his hands behind his back, as he attempts to stifle his disappointment. The whole point of this is to keep both Adrien and Emilie safe. If only *Emilie* can be saved, then it isn't an option. There could be other children but they wouldn’t be *Adrien.* They’ve invested too much time, too much love in their son, to destroy him now.

Whatever irritants Adrien might bring to his existence Gabriel has never wanted *that.* “We’ll have to focus on keeping the Miraculous safe instead then.”

For a moment he thinks he sees Nathalie’s posture relax but then she's back, as professional and non-judgemental as ever.

Emilie’s hand hesitates over her dresser before she picks up an eyeliner pencil.

Gabriel gives it little thought as he makes and remakes his tie with the perfect creases until he looks over, but when he looks back at her he's surprised, “trying a new look dear?”

Emilie shrugs, applying mascara to her eyelashes to complete the cat-eyed look she’s creating with eyeliner.

“I think it suits me, don’t you?”

He's not stupid enough to disagree with that, especially with how easily irritated she seems to have become recently. “Everything suits you my darling. You know that.”

Gabriel’s coming back from a meeting when two little child-shaped blurs almost trip him over on the way in. He resists the temptation to pinch at the bridge of his nose.

“No running in the hall Adrien,” he yells after his son, and only then pauses, *two?*

Gabriel is pretty sure he only has one child and while Tomoe, and he's so greatful to Emilie for that connection, has been allowing her daughter over to do various preschool activities with Adrien they’d been going back to Japan for at least the next few years and they’d gone out for a farewell dinner so the little girl apparently *isn’t* Kagami. And though Audrey has at least moved her daughter with André back to Paris and Emilie had said they must have her over he’d been under the impression that girl was blonde.

Though admittedly was any woman to dye a what, four year old’s hair it *would* be Audrey.

“Papa,” Adrien’s smile is *too* blinding. Too perfect to be naturally conceived, but it *will* fit perfectly in any campaign where anyone will think any child involved will have gone through years of coaching and then a thousand different shots before hitting the perfect ones, “may I show you my drawings? After dinner?”

“Oh honey,” Emilie smiles, “your father doesn’t need to be bothered by that. You know I can help you with all of them.”

Adrien’s lower lip quivers and, oh no he’d made that too effective, he’d designed this damnit. It shouldn’t work on him.

Though that said. Gabriel doesn’t actually have any reason to say no. He in fact has *no* reason to say no, he generally cedes their son’s raising to Emilie given she’s so much better at all that emotional stuff, but this is Adrien asking about something he actually *can* give feedback on.

Frankly with the amount of energy Adrien seems to have Gabriel lives in fear of the day his son develops an interest in football and he’s expected to explain the offside rule or something and he has no idea how to explain he’d hated sport in school and people had looked at his height and let him play goalie where he didn’t have to put more thought into it than not letting the ball into the net.

Possibly he'd been lacking some nuances from the reactions when he threw the ball back onto the field but honestly Gabriel counts them lucky he'd paid attention enough to guard the goal. It's not like they'd actually been friends. They certainly hadn't treated him like that.

"I'd like to see them," he says to his son, "especially since you've been so good asking at dinner instead of interrupting me at work."

Adrien beams at him, and for once Gabriel feels like he's successfully managing his son. It's not fair to compare himself to Emilie of course. She has the ring. But she makes it all look so easy as if she isn't commanding Adrien at all.

Right now Emilie looks a little displeased, "I'll go get your best ones after dinner honey. You know your father is a very busy man. He won't have time to look through them all."

"But," Adrien's lip quivers, "I wanted to show him my favourites."

"It's no problem," he says, "I have the evening free." An unusual occurrence these days, but things going astonishingly well with the brand. *Too* well even. He hadn't exactly meant to miss out on so much of his son's childhood, especially given how Emilie had been sure Adrien's personality would develop like any child, but he can't look away *now* and anyway Emilie does seem to have their son well in hand.

Never mind that Adrien seems to also have his mother well distracted. Despite its ever-present place above Emilie's heart she's not mentioned the Miraculous in months.

Adrien's smile returns immediately.

"I'll have Nathalie collect them for us as we wait for desert," Gabriel announces.

Emilie's attention is suddenly torn away from Adrien, "Nathalie's still here?"

Gabriel doesn't blush under his wife's sudden focus. It's not like he's done anything *wrong.* Just taken an evening off to be with his family like Emilie often badgers him too.

"We're waiting on an urgent fax." He explains, "she offered to run it in to me to get my signature once it arrived so I didn't have to be the one waiting by the machine."

"Well," Emilie's voice is dry, "she's certainly devoted isn't she?"

"I thought you said that was a good thing?"

"So I did," then Emilie shakes her head, and looks oddly *younger,* "you did make sure to have a dinner made for her too?"

"Of course I did," or he'd had Nathalie tell the chief herself but that's much the same thing really.

After everything that happens almost immediately after it takes him some time to remember that small moment again, and then even longer to works out that Emilie had looked younger in that moment before their argument because she'd looked *more like she used to.*

Gabriel does his…best with the drawings.

Admittedly Adrien is still very young. But surely they should start to look like *something* by this point.

"This is," he tries to make out a triangle on top of a rectangle sure he's got it right this time, "a house?"

"No," Adrien giggles, "that's *you!*"

"Oh I see. Developing an interest in cubism are you?"

Adrien looks blank, "There's not a cube, that's,"

"Me. You said." And, OK this time he has to be right, "and this is a dog?"

Adrien nods, "Kagami drew that one."

Of course she did. Which only proves that Emilie apparently didn't choose to make Adrien an artist because his former playmate is much the same age and *her* drawings are a childish scrawl it's true but recognisable at least.

He'd ask Emilie the whys of her decision but then she'd ask the whys of his and-

Better to let sleeping dogs lie.

Taking a difference tack he decides to avoid the guessing game, "Do you have any of your mother?"

Adrien reaches for the pile, with a frown that looks like a little like Nathalie even though that makes no sense at all; Gabriel hadn't designed *that* in his son. "Here," his son pulls one out, "this is all of us."

Gabriel is a triangle and a rectangle again, but it *is* more obvious it's a person this time so maybe the others were earlier, and the yellow topped shapes are clearly Adrien and Emilie.

"And me with her," Adrien babbles as he passes him more, "and maman and…"

Gabriel doesn't take the piece of paper Adrien's holding out, "which dress is your mother wearing here son?"

As established Adrien's art is not particularly detailed. The fact this one is only coloured in blue and pink means nothing.

"The one she *always* wears when she's blue," Adrien looks at him like it's obvious, "maybe you should make her another."

He feels oddly disconnected from it all, like's he's watching himself calmly ask his son, "and is she blue often?"

Adrien pouts thinking. "When she's working. And when we play sometimes, before Brigitte comes to visit."

"Brigitte?"

"She's my best friend."

They have categorically never discussed a Brigitte coming over to play with Adrien.

Gabriel's heart hammers in his chest. "Come on Adrien. Let's go see if Nathalie will put you to bed. I have to talk to your mother."

Adrien notices nothing of course, "will Na'lie read me a story?"

"Na-tha-lie," he sounds out correctly to Adrien, "and she *might,* if you say her name right and ask politely."

"I don't know what you're talking about," Emilie says, "Adrien has an active imagination. He gets that from you you know. Perhaps I've told him a few fairy stories about the Miraculous but,"

Rages surges inside of him, and gives him a bluntness that he usually *doesn't* have with Emilie. "Don't lie to me," he spits, "*dear.*"

"Alright," she stands up from the bed and squares her shoulders, "perhaps I have been. You don't understand how bereft Adrien's been in Kagami's absence. I couldn't let our son suffer," she puts her hand on his shoulder, "I just want the best for our family."

"Emilie," with his other hand he cups her face, "you don't have to shoulder all this yourself. I know I let you think that before and it overwhelmed you remember? I didn't even know you'd worked out how to do multiple sentimonsters. You don't have to exhaust yourself to give Adrien a friend. We'll just have Chloé over."

“I suppose,” she looks confused, “but isn’t Bridgette *better?* We know she won’t lead Adrien astray, and she’s the cutest little thing- I was going to just remake Kagami but I was worried about confusing Adrien, and then I thought, wouldn’t it be sweet for Adrien to have his own little Nathalie following him around, so I put a little of her in there. And me, in lieu of an actual sibling I guess.”

Gabriel lets go of her. “You *what?*”

“I can change it if you want,” she shrugs.

His stomach feels like it’s turned upside down inside him. “*That’s,* Emilie, why would you even *do* that.”

“I told you,”

“No,” he interrupts, “*you* told me that Adrien was special, that he was *human* and not just a puppet to use and now you’re making parodies of people we know, just like him, that you’re creating and dismissing for *fun?*”

“Not for fun for,*”*

“Us. That’s what you said, but it doesn’t feel like that when you hide this from me.” He runs his hands through his hair in despair, “hell, *you* were the one who wanting to invite Chloé over because you were sure Audrey barely notices the child, and thought it would be good for her as well as Adrien.”

It’s an argument Gabriel had thought utterly stupid; he could hardly be expected to care about whether it was good for Chloé. His responsibility was about if it was good for *Adrien.* But it’s *for* Adrien’s sake that he’ll throw Emilie’s argument back at her.

“Why would I say that?”

“I don’t know. Maybe if you hadn’t started wearing that Miraculous again you’d be able to tell me.”

He reaches out for it and Emilie let’s out a sound that’s almost a hiss, stepping back from him.

“Duusu, *transform me.*”

Mayura is still shorter than him, but Gabriel’s well aware that doesn’t matter, that those slim limbs hold a strength no one would guess from looking at them.

He holds his hands up. “There’s no need for that.”

She arches an eyebrow. “Weren’t you trying to take it?”

“I just want to be able to stop you harming yourself. I can keep it and Adrien safe as much as you can.”

“No,” she shakes her head,” you can’t. I’m the only one who can do this Hawk Moth, you.”

“What did you just call me?”

“Gabriel.” She says, “I said Gabriel.”

“No. No, you said,”

“It doesn’t matter!” She shouts, “what matters is that I *can’t* just stop. You need Mayura.”

“I need my wife.”

“I don’t think we’re in disagreement there,” she says.

“We *are.* I need *Emilie.*”

She laughs, “that’s what you think. Do you think your brand is doing *so well* because of *you?* Because of your” she makes quotation marks, “talent. Your hard work that keeps you and Nathalie busy in the Atelier all day? Oh your business wouldn’t exist without that but the reason it’s all accelerated recently is *me,”*

It suddenly doesn’t feel like it would be so back to throw a punch. It’s not like it would *hurt* her after all.

“Yes, you introduced me to Audrey but,”

She laughs. Or if there’s such a thing as a beautiful cackle, the sort of thing that freezes you with both horror and awe, then she does that.

“Oh my dearest stupid husband. That’s not what I’m talking about at all.” She storms back over to him, closing her hand over his shoulder like a trap, “*I’m* the one who reads the emotions of everyone you introduce me too, and even those you don’t and then *use* that information to make sure we give them what they want. *I’m* the one whose sentimonsters have in varying different ways got blackmail on most of Parisian high society and the international fashion world to boot. *I’m* the one who’s got us varying concessions and information.”

“What?”

Her claws dig into him, painfully hard, “you need me.”

“Emilie,”

“Mayura,” she corrects him, “and I love you and we can do this together, but Gabriel?”

His throat is almost too tight to say, “yes?”

“Remember I can make a sentimonster of *you* too. If you try to take the brooch or my son from me I can easily ruin your reputation.”

In the morning Emilie cries over the cuts on the back of his shoulder she maintains she doesn’t remember making.

Chapter 3

“I *want* to be me,” Emilie says, her knuckles white with her grip on her coffee mug, “I just… forget that sometimes.”

Gabriel isn’t even sure Emilie *knows* how to be herself. Mayura appears more often than he’d like, and Emilie’s confused as to who she is even more often, but even when she’s Emilie and she *knows* she’s Emilie he doesn’t think she’s the Emilie he married.

He can’t remember that Emilie, except to know that today, the most lucid she’s been in months is also the closest she’s been to that Emilie in months.

Or he thinks so anyway.

“Perhaps you should let me wear that brooch given your fears for Adrien.” He suggests. He knows she’ll never countenance taking it off even as it destroys her.

Emilie smiles weakly, her hair hanging down around her face, “and have Adrien lose both his parents?”

A fierce certainty burns inside him, “he’s not going to lose you.”

Hope might seem some far off thing, buried behind the mountains of obstacles he has to surmount, but he refuses to give up. He made her vows to support her and Gabriel Agreste doesn’t break his promises.

Even when they feel like traps.

Her eyes shimmer with unspent tears, and the shining shade is burnt into his mind and there’s the dominant tone for his next collection.

Sorrow. Maybe. Or perhaps *Loss.* He’ll come up with a theme anyway. The best art is made from suffering isn’t it?

Emilie takes a sip of her coffee. “Thank you.”

He grunts, uncomfortable with her praise, “I haven’t done anything yet.”

“Not many men would have the strength to stand by me this through this.”

“This is happening because you have to keep our son safe. How could I do otherwise?”

She looks up at him, “You’re a good man Gabriel. I love you.”

“I love you too.” He tells himself it’s not a lie.

Mayura knows that he doesn't like her anymore now he knows the truth of her. She pretends she doesn't but Gabriel recognises the assessing nature of her eyes on him. They mirror the expression in his own.

They both know Gabriel wants to rescue Emilie from this possession, and they both pretend they don't. Him, from fear of her reaction and she, well-

"You're ignoring me," Mayura pouts, hanging onto his arm.

He tries to ignore the soft press of her body against his side. Revulsion fills his gut in her presence, and yet the rest of his body doesn't seem to have got the memo from its physical reaction to her.

"I'm working," he tries to point out.

She leans forward pointing at a stripe on the dress on his screen, "that would look better in a darker colour."

Unfortunately she's right, and despite the wave cresting in the constant well of irritation her presence creates on him he makes the necessary adjustment.

"Don't be surprised," she says, "I'm a designer too in my own way after all."

He hadn't thought of that but, "I suppose you are."

It's strange. Where Mayura has traits that aren't, or at least he *thinks* aren't Emilie's and he has to believe that because the alternative is that's she's just a facet of Emilie and not something coming from the Peacock, they're all negative. She and he aren't supposed to have common ground.

"I can't wait to see the effects of your akumas."

A shiver goes down his spine. "Why would I be sending out akumas?"

"Oh," Mayura smirks, "you'll find a reason. I'm sure of that. Now give me a kiss."

Her intonation is so like Emilie's that he does it automatically before he realises his mistake, and by then it's too late because Mayura quite clearly has no plans to let him go; dragging him down the stairs and into the depression around the catwalk.

It's not the first time he reminds himself. He'd done it back when he thought Mayura was just the name Emilie used when transformed. It's all *so* familiar in fact that it doesn't feel like he's kissing someone new, kissing someone he *refuses* to believe is his wife, at all.

It's safer to go along with it he tells himself.

Mayura will trust him more if he does he justifies.

It's for the best if she cares for him because he knows she could destroy him, ruin him, *kill* him, if she wanted. That's his mantra as he lets her push him to the ground and straddle him.

And then he doesn't think about much because it's all just the same and also so very different, but he doesn't need to think to do this.

Until he hears Nathalie's gasp and the sound of the door swinging shut and he's suddenly full of that sickly slick guilt he's been becoming so familiar with.

His face is hot the next time he sees Nathalie. "I,"

"Your private life isn't my business monsieur."

That doesn't make him feel better because whatever she says he can see the judgement in her eyes.

"It's for the best Mayura is disposed positively to me. That she doesn't think I want to get rid of her, that she thinks I've accepted her. It gives me more of an opportunity to negotiate."

Judgement turns to interest. "Negotiate?"

"Look," he curls the short layer at the front of Mayura's hair around his finger hoping beyond hope that this will work, that she'll believe him infatuated, "you can't be Mayura around Adrien."

He's kept a closer eye on her since the drawings, and while Bridgette never manifests again as far as he can tell, and while she never transforms while Chloé is around, she does still transform around their son.

Making little sentimonster puppets to tell him stories, or using her increased strength to carry Adrien up over her head making him "fly" even though he's too little for that.

She glares at his, "Why can't I be myself around my son?"

Gabriel breathes in and tries to swallow the urge to yell at her that she's *not* herself and that's exactly the problem.

"You love Adrien don't you?"

He knows that much. See's the adoration in Mayura's eyes every second she's with Adrien.

“Of course.” Emilie seems to reassert herself over pink eyes and blue skin for a moment.

It feels like seeing a ghost.

The important thing though is that, though Gabriel doesn’t understand why, is that Mayura *does* seem to view him as her husband and Adrien as her son, so this has a chance of working.

“Adrien’s too young to understand the need to keep this secret,” he begs her, and he might not be being quite truthful about his concerns but his emotions are very real, “you need,”

“To look like I’m not using a Miraculous,” Mayura sighs, “yes I can see your point. Though I mean, we’re homeschooling Adrien aren’t we? Is it really a problem?”

Gabriel starts. He hadn’t realised Mayura would remember that of his and Emilie’s conversations. Especially given one that *could* have reflected harshly on her own work, given he and Emilie had worried someone in the outside world might realise Adrien was born differently, where they’re all too used to him in this house to tell. “He’ll have tutors. And he does need to do *some* kind of sport,” for his health anyway though he pities Adrien having to interact with those sort of children, “which probably means a team.”

“You’re right I suppose,” she pouts. “I’m going to miss him though.”

It’s as close an admission to that she and Emilie aren’t one and same as he’s ever got from Mayura.

For the first time ever he sees tears in Mayura’s eyes, “do I have to make him forget me until he’s older?”

Gabriel forgets they can do that. Neither Emilie or Mayura seem to take to take control of Adrien really, despite all her promises to do so when they’d been conceiving him, and for some reason the notion makes him feel odd now. Still, “it would probably be for the best. I’m sorry.”

“I can try not to use the Miraculous I suppose,” says Emilie, “I just don’t feel like I’m contributing if I’m not.”

“You don’t need to *contribute.* We’re doing well. I’m going well. You can stop.”

“Oh Gabriel, you don’t know what I’ve done.”

“I don’t *care.* Just try for me my dear Emilie?”

“OK,” she nods. “I’ll try.”

Mayura keeps her promises better than Emilie does.

It's uncomfortable how furtive he feels as he and Nathalie board the plane for Japan. It's quite natural for his assistant to accompany him, and for his wife to stay behind looking after his son but as the doors shut on the jet and he and Nathalie are left alone but for the pilots he thinks this must be how it feels to have an affair.

Constantly looking over your shoulder as you try to pretend you're talking about nothing more personal than work.

Nathalie gets up before the plane starts taxiing and returns to her seat with two glasses of clear liquid in her hand.

"What is this?"

"Vodka, monsieur."

It's strange discovering he still has the capability to be shocked. "Really?"

"I think we both might need it."

"You're coming dangerously close to overstepping you know." He stares down at Nathalie and just as she looks about to break he concedes, "But you're probably right."

There's silence for a while as they both sip at the drinks as the starts to reach the runway. As it accelerates for take-off he says, "She's getting worse isn't she?"

"I don't see her the way you do but," Nathalie hesitates, "yes."

He pinches at the bridge of his nose, waiting for the engine noise to recede a little, and his eardrums to adjust to the altitude rise. "And our ideas?"

Nathalie nods, glad to have something to offer from the look of it, "I've been in touch with various jewellers and manufacturers. I believe it *is* possible to produce counterparts of how the Peacock Miraculous looks while Emilie wears it."

It's a good plan now they know that it could actually work but the issue is that it will only work, "Until she tries to transform."

"Yes." Nathalie confirms, "although I have had an idea,"

“An idea?”

“I realise that the situation is,” she pauses, “delicate and that you don’t want to share this with others but. Perhaps it would be worth talking with Mme. Tsurugi while we’re in Japan? Her company’s technology might actually be capable of faking a change in appearance, and she was Emilie’s friend.”

“You think Emilie wouldn’t notice not transforming?”

“I don’t know sir.”

“I appreciate your honesty.” Unfortunately she might also be *right* if Emilie’s claims to be unware of what she’s doing at times are true. “I suppose you’re set up the meeting already?”

“I’ve set up a meeting to explore wearable technology. I know you were looking into having parts of the Butterfly collection move on the models.”

“I’ll meet her. What about I’ll decide later.”

It works for a while. Emilie doesn’t get better, but she doesn’t get worse either. And she doesn’t seem to notice when Gabriel forces a break in her use of the Miraculous those time he swaps them out.

He’d like to do it more often but he knows he’s pushing it as is. Knows that at least the fact he sleeps less hours than her is helping him manage to protect her unconscious brain while she sleeps.

He tries to help other ways too. When Emilie buys clothes that are too Mayura he has Nathalie secretly return them and replace them with things more like what Emilie had favoured before she ever picked up that Miraculous.

“It’s a pity,” Nathalie says once, “they are always exquisite.”

Inside himself he shudders. They *are.* Mayura does have taste. And on Mayura they’d be stunning- why she never changes her transformation he never knows. But that Mayura’s body is Emilie’s, and the idea of Emilie herself wearing them, looking like *Mayura* while her hair is still blonde and her eyes are still green, feels like a violation of all that’s right in the world.

Externally he just shrugs, “if there’s anything you like you can have it.”

It’s not the money that’s the problem. Not when half the time Emilie’s raiding the Gabriel brand’s own archives.

There’s a hint of laughter on Nathalie’s lips, “I think they’re a little revealing for my tastes.”

But her hand hovers over a midnight velvet dress anyway. Gabriel recalls it as long-sleeved and modest from the front but with a plunging back. He deliberately doesn't imagine Nathalie in it.

The funny thing is that Gabriel can't even totally blame Emilie for forgetting what her name is when he's found himself reacting to "Hawk Moth" when she calls him that recently.

It makes him glad he's far too busy with other things to even think about using the Butterfly Miraculous.

Gabriel automatically follows Nathalie down the corridor from the hotel room they'd met the pop star he's to dress for the premiere of her first film appearance in, into another room.

This is routine now and they're lucky that the press has never noticed their rendez-vous in places outside the house were Emilie can't listen.

He sits down on the bed. "What's she done now?"

"I think you should consider sending Adrien to school." Nathalie says.

"What?" It's the last thing he'd expected her to say, "why?"

Nathalie *knows* the myriad of reasons they don't spend Adrien to school from his minor concern about having made Adrien too perfect for people not to notice, to Adrien's safety when he could be stalked or abducted out there, to how Emilie had hated her school and Gabriel hadn't any particularly positive experiences about his to make him think it worth it, to the negative influences who could act on their son out there, to the fact that at home they can control his education and give him a more holistic syllabus.

"I know that having Adrien at home is better for Mme. Agreste." That's something they both know. Looking after Adrien keeps Emilie occupied, and Mayura's agreement not to transform around Adrien any longer is one of the only thing that keeps Emilie from transforming all the time. "But I think that it might not be for the best for Adrien I…"

When she seems to lose her trail of thought he gets impatient, "You *what* Nathalie?"

"I worry for Adrien's safety. We know she can be erratic, and there's been a number of incidences recently when you've sent me to fetch either of them where I've been concerned."

Gabriel has noticed nothing and it makes him short with Nathalie, “concerned? Are you saying you believe Emilie would *hurt* Adrien?”

He doesn’t believe that. Can’t believe that. Emilie *loves* Adrien. Hell even Mayura loves Adrien.

“Not deliberately.” Nathalie says, “but her judgement is impaired and, well, how she handled Bridgette does suggest a rather blithe disregard for creating and destroying human sentimonsters. I worry that in our concern for Mme. Agreste we’ve not concerned enough with Adrien.”

He gets up to reassert himself against Nathalie. “Adrien is nothing like Bridgette. Adrien has grown like any human child.”

Nathalie takes a step back, “I know but,”

“And Emilie would never treat him like that. She’s his *mother,* and we decided how we wanted to raise Adrien together as his parents.”

He doesn’t realise that he’s taken another step forward until Nathalie takes another one away and her back hits the wall.

“I know that but,”

“Perhaps with everything I’ve asked you to do, and all our secrets that you’re privy to, you’ve forgotten Mlle. Sancoeur that *I pay you* to assist me. You’re not here to tell me what to do. If you want to stay here,” Emilie’s old comment about what Nathalie would do for Adrien suddenly echoes in his mind, “if you want to stay in our lives, in Adrien’s lives then maybe you should remember that.”

Weakly she says, “If you fired me then I could go to the press.”

“No you wouldn’t,” in this moment it’s crystal clear she cares *too* much for that, “and if you did who would believe you? Even if someone did, well, Emilie’s quite capable of creating a sentimonster to create images to discredit you.”

“What the hell are you *doing?*”

Emilie looks up at him and dares to look surprised, and says, “Are you alright dear?”

Just “are you alright dear?” as if she’s not wielding a pair of scissors with half her hair strewn over the floor.

“Not really. What is *this?*” he gestures futilely at the hair.

“Oh I have made quite a mess haven’t I?” Emilie gasps theatrically, “you’re right. It is rather unfair to expect the cleaners to pick all that up. I’ll tidy up once I’m done.”

“Done *what?*”

“Sorting my hair. I can’t think why I let it get this long.”

Gabriel swallows his dread. “You didn’t think of going to a hairdresser?”

Emilie stops, and her expression seems to suggest even she thinks she’s just done something stupid, “that would have been a better idea wouldn’t it?”

“Yes, yes it would have been,” Gabriel says he looks at the hair she’d been so proud of strewn over the floor. “I’ll have Nathalie make you an appointment.”

For extensions to fix this but Emilie doesn’t need to know that.

He drums the stylus against his fingers, “Nathalie?”

She looks up, “Sir?”

“Could you look into what possibilities we have for Adrien to model coming up? It’s time to up his public exposure and to tie him to the image of the brand. Emilie will chaperone he of course. I think it would do them both good to spend some more time with other people.”

It’s not an apology.

Thunder rumbles through the house.

It’s a bright sunny day outside with not a cloud in the sky.

Gabriel curses and runs to the lift to the loft. His heart beats a million kilometres per hour as he waits in it, unable to speed things up and he bursts into the room to find Mayura collapsed on the floor.

“Emilie,” he begs, gathering her into his arms as he rips off the Miraculous, “Emilie wake up.”

She blinks her eyes open, “I’m so tired.”

“What happened?”

Emilie still looks hazy and confused, as if she doesn’t quite know, or doesn’t know what she’s saying, but in a whisper she manages. “I think maybe I pushed too far.”

Mayura starts coughing.

He’s never thought about it but she’s never done that before.

“Are you alright?”

“Just a tickle.”

Emilie’s been coughing a while. She’s always had allergies though, banishing any dust from the mansion so she can breathe, and at first he doesn’t put it together.

Nathalie rings him, her usual calm tones completely absent, “Mme. Agreste’s just fainted. We’re at the hospital.”

Gabriel stares in horror at the blood she’s spat onto his bare shoulder.

“I’m so sorry!” she frantically gets a tissue to wipe it off him.

“Sorry? Are you *alright?”*

It’s just from coughing too much.” Emilie says, “the doctor’s given me an inhaler. I’ll be fine.”

“Father,” Adrien fidgets, clearly aware he’s interrupting, but that makes Gabriel’s ears prick up because this must be something Adrien deems important enough to be impolite, “is something wrong with my mother? She keeps getting dizzy spells and she’s coughing *all the time.*”

He leaves his tablet to walk round to his son, and places a reassuring hand on his shoulder. “Just a cold she can’t shake off Adrien. She’ll be fine.” But he hesitates, “how often would you say she looks dizzy?”

Adrien’s face fills with panic.

“I just want to tell the doctor in case she needs more medicine.”

Adrien tells him.

It’s much worse than Gabriel had thought.

The doctor’s face is serious. “M.Agreste I have to ask you again. Are you sure your wife isn’t taking any form of drugs?”

“Emilie barely even drinks,” he answers quite honestly.

The woman’s face is clearly unconvinced, “I have to suggest again that we take Mme. Agreste into hospital.”

“No, that’s not an option.” He can’t have Mayura, and all of *this,* and *Adrien* come out in a public forum, “Emilie doesn’t do well with new environments.”

“M.Agreste your wife’s lungs are failing for no apparent reason. She needs oxygen, she needs to be somewhere we can intervene or she could die.”

“I’ll have my assistant make arrangements for the necessary equipment to be bought here and,” he stares into the woman’s soul wondering what Emilie has on her, and then smiles in a way he’s been told looks like a shark, “I’m glad to know we can rely on your discretion.”

“Emilie?” He sits down next to her with the lunch he’s brought in, “how are you doing today?”

She frowns, “Who’s Emilie?”

“*You’re* Emilie.”

“No,” she says. “I’m Mayura. But,” she seems to think hard, “yes I remember Emilie. I didn’t dislike her but,” she shrugs, “I’m stronger you see?”

He almost wants to strangle her even though it would have the opposite effect of what he wanted, “You’re killing both of you. What could be important enough to do this?”

She reaches up and brushes his hair back, “I’m sorry I’ve hurt you, this hasn’t worked out how I hoped. But existence is worth death. You’ll understand that one day.”

Gabriel is slumped over in his chair. Hand to his forehead, “she’s not going to stop is she?”

Nathalie kneels down beside him, “I’m don’t think so. Whatever she’s doing it for it seems to be the only thing she cares about.”

He looks at her, “she’s killing herself isn’t she?”

Nathalie swallows, and shuts her eyes, “yes. I wish, for your and Adrien’s sakes, I wish there was a way we could just stop her, but unless there’s a Miraculous that could just, I don’t know. Make her sleep until we found a solution to this, because right now I don’t think even separating her from the Miraculous would help. Her body’s too damaged. We need something stronger than the Peacock Miraculous to fix this.”

Gabriel stares at her as everything she’s just said slots into one terrible beautiful cohesive whole in his head. Even her pushing him years ago to discuss technology with Tomoe might yet work out. And they’re both pretty certain the issue with using the Peacock Miraculous is due to it being broken. The few times before this had escalated when he had used the Butterfly Miraculous he’d never felt any such effects.

He grabs the woman who might have just worked out how he can save his family into a hug, and says, “Nathalie you’re a genius.”

“I…am?”

“You have the barbiturates?”

“Yes.” Nathalie is as serious as he’s ever seen her. *More* serious than she was on that night years ago when they’d both thought they might die until Emilie rescued them.

“And the life-support casket is ready?”

He’s stalling for time. He knows that. But inducing a coma in his wife without her knowledge and against her will isn’t the sort of thing one does without hesitating. Even if it’s the only way to save her from a Peacock demon.

“I’ve triple-checked it.” Then she spares him from needing to think up another delaying question, “is she asleep?”

It would have been easier to do it when she was sedated but it’s too risky, the chance of killing her would have been too high, and Gabriel is doing all of this to *save* Emilie.

A doctor could have done it. Might well have found it easier to give her one IV for the pain and then change what was being fed into her system without her noticing but good as research as Nathalie is, and precise as Gabriel is, neither of them are specialist medical professionals and Nathalie is the only one he trusts with this.

“She is.”

Emilie wakes up the moment they rip the Peacock Miraculous off her but without it, especially weak as she is, she’s unable to fight them off despite the best efforts of her teeth and her nails.

Gabriel holds her down, as still as he can make her despite her struggles while Nathalie jabs the IV into her arm. It’s messier than either of them would have liked, and where he’ll muster her the energy to carry her downstairs he doesn’t know but he *has* to or risk her heart or lungs stopping pumping.

“Gabriel why,” Emilie begs him with terror in her eyes, “what are you, please don’t kill me, please, Gabriel *please.*”

Once the drugs start flowing it takes less than a minute for her eyes to close.

Chapter 4

“I told you never to use the Peacock Miraculous,” Gabriel says, letting Nathalie down into the chair.

She struggles even to open her eyes, “there wasn’t another option, I couldn’t let you get caught. Couldn’t let all of this be for nothing.”

The meaning hovers between them. She and him have done all of this, have terrorised the city, have attacked Adrien’s friends, have *forcibly* put Emilie into a coma all to save Emilie’s life and sanity.

If they fail then suddenly there’s no justification for any of that.

Never mind what might happen with Emilie, to Adrien, with both of them stuck behind bars.

He takes her hand, “you won’t have to do this again Nathalie I promise, I won’t leave the lair. You’ll be alright, Emilie must have used it hundreds of times before she...”

“I know,” she attempts to squeeze his hand back but her grip is weak.

The Peacock Miraculous wasn’t this broken when Emilie started using it.

Nathalie’s already suffering physically.

It had been a swift spiral down from when Emilie was at this point.

This time Gabriel knowns better than to let Nathalie wear it. He takes it away from her like he never did for Emilie. He tells her straight to her face never to use it like he never did for Emilie.

It’s ironic that it had been himself that he’d worried for when they’d started this. He’d seen a Miraculous consume his wife and now he was planning to wear one *himself.* But the Butterfly isn’t broken, or at least not that he and Nathalie can tell and he hasn’t noticed any bleed through from Hawk Moth to Gabriel.

Though he doesn’t know if he *would.*

Still, Nathalie hasn’t mentioned anything so for now all he can do is assume that he’s safe.

And *hope* that she is.

She's certainly been affected by the Miraculous. She never used to get tired this easily and he's noticed her trying to hide her coughs.

It's not like Emilie was.

He doesn't fear for her life.

Yet.

But that the effects are visible at all after having only used it once is worrying.

He makes sure to keep a sharper eye on Nathalie, instead of trusting her to quietly keep industrially working in the background the way he used to.

And she seems…fine.

He thinks.

Nathalie used to help tutor Adrien.

And she loves him. Emilie had told him that.

But still, when he opens the door to the dining room and finds her intently explaining a bit of history to his son with her arm over his shoulder a shiver goes down his spine.

Mayura had been hurt by her separation from Adrien.

Much as he despises her he knows that.

Nathalie's always been attentive to him because *that's her job,* and the moment he and Emilie had realised the seriousness of their plan and decided to offer her a continuing role with them Nathalie has never been anything other than serious about it.

So it's not weird for her eyes to follow him around. It's *useful.* It's how she anticipates his needs before he does.

Only sometimes now, when he feels her eyes on him, he feels like prey.

Does Mayura know what they did to her?

She must if she's Nathalie's memories.

There's an electric current between him and Nathalie when they get in sync.

If Emilie once, in the days before Mayura, had softened him, had been the velvet glove to his iron fist then Nathalie is not exactly the opposite but something close to it. The whetstone to his sword, making use of all the information Mayura had gathered.

He's harsher now, but just as effective.

There's something wrong in eyes meeting in shared delight over engineering a teenager's despair but Gabriel forgets to feel that these days.

Only sometimes he'd forcibly dragged out of his glee when Nathalie's expression seems more Mayura's than her own.

But it's no massive change like it was with Emilie. It's something subtle. Mayura is more expressive than Nathalie true, but there's a similarity to how they smirk, and that little furrow between their eyebrows, and that pout when things don't get their way. But it *is* different on Mayura's face. Magnified somehow.

Yet Nathalie only used that Miraculous *once.* And he's already worrying about it. A little Mayura is to be expected.

He tells himself he's seeing things.

Only-

Nathalie frowns at the floor, "it's not winning. Just sending out akumas you know. We need,"

"I *have* plans." He reminds her, "we'll think of more. Stop trying to get me to let you use that Miraculous."

It's not the first time she's hinted about using the Miraculous and much as he hates it he's also certain that it won't be the last. He's seen that yearning in her eyes he used to see in Emilie's. Seen her eyes slide past him to the safe hidden behind him.

She sighs, "I just,"

"Nathalie," he takes her hands in his, they're cold and *that* makes him worry but then he doesn't know how they usually feel, "you *know* the dangers. You're not going into this blind like Emilie was. How could you even consider using it again? The last time was my fault for

getting caught, I know you didn't have other options, and I'm thankful to you for risking yourself like that for me," he squeezes her hands, "*so* thankful. But you don't have to do it again. It's Nathalie I need by my side, not Mayura. Was one try *really* that tempting?"

Every cell in his body begs that it isn't. While he lost Emilie he had Nathalie by his side. If he loses Nathalie then he'll have no one.

Gabriel doesn't have many friends. He's never been a team-player. He's been called an egoist more than once.

But this he can't do alone.

"I don't know," she says hollowly, "and I suppose I can't can I? You told me she didn't. And it's worse now, we both know that but…"

"But?"

"It was *my* fault this happened to Emilie. How is it fair that she's down there in that thing, and I've got away with it scot free?"

Gabriel swallows, "you very much have not got off with it scot free,"

"Now but,"

"Was this really what you hoped for? When we asked you to stay on?"

The barest hint of a smile pulls at her face under empty eyes, "No."

"I know you thought you'd get to see Miracles. Instead you ended up killing my wife with me."

"She's not dead."

"Isn't she?"

Nathalie leans forward a little, "No. We're going to save her. And *Adrien* is a Miracle. Besides I also wanted steady employment and the chance to put down roots, and I certainly got that."

Gravity seems to inexorably drag him towards her, "thank you for moving in. Adrien and I would never manage without you."

"I wasn't going to turn down free rent in this city."

Despite the closeness of faces he's able to look at her with the full force of her scepticism.

Their foreheads touch and Gabriel shuts his eyes, "you're not the reason this happened to Emilie. You're a very good researcher but we'd have found someone else eventually, you know Emilie's determination."

“I do.” He doesn’t need to see her face to know the chagrined expression on it.

“You’re the only reason I’ve been able to *cope* with everything that’s happened to Emilie.” He says. “Stay with me. I can’t go through it again.”

“I will.” Her breath brushes against his lips like a kiss.

He comes to wake in a burst of startlement and confusion. For a moment he doesn’t understand where he is until he realises he’s sat in one of the chairs in front of the fire downstairs.

A hand pulls off him, and he looks up to see Nathalie, her brows arcing down, as she looks down at him in concern, “sir you really do need to sleep more.”

“The words, pot. Kettle. Black. Come to mind Nathalie.”

This time her hand comes to rest over his collarbone and Gabriel leans into the comfort offered and her thumb brushes over her cheek.

“The brand isn’t called Nathalie you know?” She says, “and you’re not letting me share the burden of the Miraculous. It’s important you get enough rest to keep both enterprises going.”

“I know,” he grouches, “that’s the problem. I don’t have the time to waste on sleep.”

She bends down without ever letting go of him, “it’s not a waste when we both need you fit and well. Come on Gabriel.”

Taking him his hand with her free one she tugs him upright and he grumpily lets her pull him to his bedroom, before letting him go.

“Good night,” she smiles, and before he can disagree she presses a kiss to his cheek, turns on her heel and leaves the room.

He stands still for far too long.

Then he brings his hand up to where she’d kissed him.

And it wasn’t just the kiss was it?

Because now out of her presence how she’d cupped his face seems equally wrong.

He and Nathalie are comfortable with each over yes, and he can’t deny he’s gotten used to the little bits of physical reassurance they trade back and forth between each other but Nathalie’s never, Nathalie *doesn’t,* do anything as romantically charged as that before.

Only.

He can no longer be certain that it's *only* Nathalie inside her head anymore.

And Mayura had been quite blatant in her attraction to him.

Which is odd now he thinks about it. He'd thought it transference from Emilie but if it's carried through that brooch to Nathalie then perhaps not.

The reassuring answer is that for Mayura it's simply a physical attraction, and a means to an end. A way she'd thought she'd control him.

Sometimes though he has wondered. About Adrien. And about how much their son was Emilie's idea and how much of that was Mayura tearing apart the logic of mind even back then. Had Mayura wanted a son with *him?*

Gabriel has quite a healthy sense of self-esteem. You have to have to go from growing out in a family of blue collar workers to become a billionaire with an empire build in fashion. And he'd never have believed what he and *Emilie,* beautiful gifted moneyed Emilie, was real if he didn't think he was capable of that.

He's rich. He's talented. He's a shrewd businessman. He's tall and striking, perhaps rather than traditionally handsome, but he's a man so he can get away with that, can carry it *off* in a way that's got him various unsavoury offers over the years, and his foot in with various grand dames. He can be, when he wants to be, charismatic in a way that bowls people over. The remainder of the time he's haughty in a way that some woman and even some men take as a challenge.

That a woman might want him isn't what he struggles to understand.

It's that-

All of that seems very little to someone like Mayura.

Why would any of his achievements in his fleeting mortal life entrance a being aeons old like that?

But then maybe she isn't.

He and Nathalie are sure it's the damage to the brooch that's let this personality form and they don't know when that happened. *Duusu* is millennia old. Perhaps Mayura is only as old as when Emilie put that brooch on. Perhaps Gabriel is the only man that's ever known her in that capacity.

The coil of possessiveness in his gut that stirs surprises him.

Mayura is not the person he really wants. That's *Emilie.* Besides Mayura had certainly never felt like any untouched innocent.

And of course Mayura, should she appear, is no longer his wife.

He *needs* to remember that.

Needs to remember that Nathalie is his closest more loyal companion and to reward her trust with such a betrayal while she isn't in control of herself would be a sin blacker than any he's committed so far.

Needs to forget how natural downstairs had felt and that emptiness when she'd left him alone in the bedroom.

Needs to forget how for a moment something broken in him had felt fixed.

Then Hawk Moth makes a mistake.

He's going to fail again, he needs something, "I need a boost."

"I'm here," Nathalie says behind him, "Duusu, *transform me.*"

He turns in horror to see Mayura.

And it *is* Mayura.

He hadn't seen her the last time Nathalie transformed but this, this is the same woman he'd seen before.

Same dress.

Same hair.

Same make-up.

Same...face?

That doesn't make sense. Everything about Mayura's style, every single bit of her colouration might have been different to Emilie, yet it had been *his wife's* face under there painted a strange hue.

But now Nathalie stands there with the same face. Same slim nose, and high cheekbones, and lips which Gabriel remembers the sensation of against his skin.

Yet if he squints and concentrates he thinks he can see Nathalie, blue-skinned and pink-eyed, too.

In some sort of daze he reaches out and traces down her body and again Mayura-Emilie but Nathalie too seems to full the contours of it.

It’s the damnedest double vision and he forgets the fight until Mayura shakes her head a little charmingly, “Hawk Moth? Your plan?”

He inhales sharply. Mayura was not the plan at all, and he’d told Nathalie no but now she’s here, now she’s *already* transformed would it do so much damage to let her take part this time?

He carries her to bed afterwards cursing himself for forgetting that the danger is no longer just Mayura. Is no longer just to Nathalie’s *mind* but also to her very physical body.

Emilie as Mayura they might have managed.

Emilie dead. No.

And that’s not an option for Nathalie either.

“I’m sorry,” Nathalie offers after she’s had enough rest that she’s actually *able* to. There’s none of the demurring, or claims to not know what she’s doing Emilie had used to offer.

He *thinks* that’s a good thing.

He doesn’t actually know.

“Why do it?”

“I think,” she blows air out through her nose, “you best try and not prompt me. I think I can resist *using* it.”

“But you took it.”

“I did take it.”

“But you won’t use it?”

She pauses. Clearly thinks. He’ll give her that much and he oh so hopes that she *is* self-aware, that she is cognizant, that this isn’t just Mayura learning from her mistakes with Emilie.

“For now not unless you encourage it. Or say something that could be *interpreted* as encouraging it.”

“For now.”

She shuts her eyes. “For now.”

Gabriel needs to win this thing soon or he’s going to destroy his professional partner the way he did his personal one.

He focuses on treating Nathalie’s physical symptoms. Has her regularly checked over by a doctor and ignores the mistrustful gaze of a person who remembers Emilie’s own issues, and is clearly wondering just how far confidentiality goes when you suspected someone of being on the verge of serial killerdom.

Rather far Gabriel would assume when that man holds footage his wife took of you with a sentimonster in a shape that could cause rather a lot of harm to your reputation. Being struck off the registry. Perhaps even jail.

And besides Gabriel is every bit the solicitous…boss with Nathalie. Taking her to appointments. Making sure she takes her medication. Forcing her to rest.

He even ends up resting more *himself* when he lies down beside Nathalie to ensure she does.

And in his attempts to distract Nathalie from the Miraculous and to focus her mind on other things he ends up doing it to himself as well. He’s plays chess with her and realises how deeply he’d missed the time to think about, to *do,* something unimportant.

It would almost be nice if it wasn’t for the fact he’s also in a constant back and forth with Nathalie over taking that Miraculous from her.

It hurts to see her now on the other side of this oh so deadly game.

“I’m the only one that can bring it to life,” Nathalie’s eyes haven’t left the dormant sentimonster on her tablet.

“We don’t have to.”

“But you want to don’t you?” she finally gets up and walks over to him, “let me do this for you Gabriel.”

He really shouldn’t let her.

But.

It's a novel chance they've not had before and if he doesn't take every chance to win this then he'll never save both Nathalie and Emilie.

Odd as it is he owes Nathalie the right to risk herself so she can *save* herself.

"Alright." He agrees taking hold of her wrists, "but the moment that thing is under my control you're going to come back to the lair and drop your transformation."

She comes back to the lair.

She doesn't drop her transformation.

He forgets to remember this is wrong as she slips in under his arm and curls into his side.

Mayura's pink eyes are so familiar as she offers her reassurances as they lose, and her arms around his shoulders have happened so many times, and he dips his head down to sake his loss in her and distract her like he used to and-

Mayura's legs are around his waist before he realises this is Nathalie.

In a panic he almost shoves her off.

Her expressions try to flee her face in fear as she gasps, "Hawk Moth?"

Cursing himself he steadies her a little and takes advantage of her confusion to rip off the Miraculous.

And then he's left with Nathalie equally shocked half hanging off him.

"I'm so so sorry Nathalie." He blurts, holding onto her forearms because that at least is *safe.*

Her face is crimson, "I think that was my fault sir."

"Still," seductive as Mayura had been *he'd* kissed *her.*

Not meeting his eyes she mumbles, "Could you help me to chair?"

"Of course."

After his own idiocy *asking* Mayura to make an appearance it's no surprise she feels empowered to turn up of her own accord.

That doesn't make Gabriel feel any better about what he discovered on his phone when he wakes up. Of course Nooroo's no help. The kwami's probably in cahoots with Mayura.

"It really *was* a brilliant plan wasn't it," the hairs go up on the back of Gabriel's neck because as though the voice is Nathalie's, the words, the smug tone is all *Mayura,* "it reminded me of when I used to have Brigitte play with Adrien when he was little."

"I rather hope Brigitte didn't play with Adrien like *that.*"

"Hmm, no they always were on the same team." She says, "though usually Adrien would be the one rescuing her from the dragons back then. I did feel a little bad for Chat Noir out there not letting him save her. That's not how the game is supposed to go. Though I guess I can always bring her back again. It never was a problem before."

Gabriel feels faintly ill. "It can't have been that little playmate of Adrien's out there. That sentimonster was identical to Ladybug. And the little girl, who I *told* you never again to summon by the way looked like,"

Nathalie. Filtered through Emilie and Mayura's idea of what she'd have looked like as a child, and probably with some influence from Kagami Tsurugi as she'd been meant to be a copy of her first.

"Me," Nathalie says, and that shock, that *is* Nathalie. "She thought it would be funny to have her look like me."

Gabriel winces, "yes Mayura,"

"No," Nathalie interrupts, "that was more Emilie. She was a joint enterprise but I, why did you never tell me she was meant to look like *me?*"

"You," he stumbles, "didn't know?"

He'd thought that reaction meant she *did.*

"I didn't." Nathalie shakes her head frantically, "but *Mayura* remembers, Gabriel I think I'm remembering *her* memories."

No longer does just Nathalie's head shake. Her whole body now seems unable to stay still as if it's beyond her control, as if her soul is straining to break free.

"Hey," he gathers her into his arms, "it's alright Nathalie. It's alright. You still have yours yes?"

“Yes, but, if this goes two ways, or even if she remembers what we do to Emilie surely she’ll fight against us?”

“My dear,” he points out, “you transformed today with no prompting from me, *and* inspired by something Mayura did before. And still you went for Ladybug and Chat Noir’s Miraculous. Whatever Mayura wants,” he realises, “unless you know?”

Nathalie’s forehead furrows, “no. I feel I should. The idea itches at the back of my brain but no, all I can find is that I want to work with you to get those Miraculous.”

“So for now it seems,” He lights straight into her eyes, “much as you are *not* to use that unless I deem it completely necessary, we don’t need to worry about you sabotaging me.”

“Nathalie,” Adrien surprises Gabriel by asking when his son makes one of his sporadic appearances in the atelier, “can I get access to the digital design archives?”

She looks away from her screen, “I can certainly set you up with an appropriate log-in if your father finds it acceptable. Sir?”

Part of him is just thanking she remembered to call him that around Adrien. She does so rarely these days. But then she *is* halfway to thinking she’s his wife. Or Hawk Moth’s. Gabriel’s not quite sure.

“Why do you need access Adrien?” He asks, “You’ve never shown an interest before?”

Inside a little bit of excitement flares in his breast. Maybe this is the day Adrien will finally show a belated interest in Gabriel’s art for its own reason and not just because he’s Adrien’s father. He can imagine it. Adrien nodding along in interest while Gabriel discovers different cuts, and well, his son’s art skills haven’t improved over the years but maybe he’ll collaborate, say with the girl from the competition and Gabriel could take the two under his wing and set them up with a little diffusion line of their own.

“I saw a dress that looked familiar and I thought maybe it was a *Gabriel?* But it wasn’t anything recent so.”

“Oh.” Hopes dashed Gabriel focuses back on his work, “that seems a little unnecessary to get you fully set up on the system then. Though I’m sure Nathalie could help you.”

That it would be a waste of her time for no good reason doesn’t need to be said.

Adrien seems to take the point cringing back with his foot along the floor. “It’s just…”

“Just *what* Adrien?” He snaps in irritation. He *hopes* there’s a good reason for this.

“It’s not exactly a dress. That was sort of a lie. But I think it *reminded* me of a dress. So I was sort of hoping there was something in the collection that I was remembering. Maybe something my mother worse? That sort of seems right?”

Nathalie looks as confused as he feels from her expression behind his son.

“*What* exactly reminded you?”

Adrien’s hand goes to his neck. “Mayura actually. She sort of felt familiar to me. But that’s stupid isn’t it? There’s no way I’d know Mayura. So it must just be her outfit.”

Nathalie’s eyes widen and Gabriel’s meet them in horror.

“There are a number of outfits in the archives reminiscent of Mayura,” she says in an amazingly steady voice, “though mostly from when you were very young. I’m surprised you remember.”

“I’ve always had a good memory,” Adrien says.

It’s true.

They’d made him that way.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> So before anyone says anything, yeah the *Ladybug* and *Felix* episodes where the other way round in this AU.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Amélie and Félix have left Gabriel is alone in his own recriminations.

How can he blame his son for thinking that there's something between him and Nathalie's there's when he's the one unable to completely detach himself from the idea of Mayura being his wife?

Nathalie tries to resist. He knows she does. But he can't pretend that things aren't different between them now. That there isn't a charge that wasn't there before. That she might restrain herself in her little physical affections, a hand on his arm in reassurance, a hug after they lose, a careful redoing of his cravat, to things that could be nothing more than friendly, save for the fact they both know she didn't offer them before despite the camaraderie of their shared secrets.

She's fighting to not think she's his wife.

The least Gabriel can do is make it clear he's not her husband.

Yet he can't quite muster the strength to push her away. He misses Emilie. He misses having a partner. He…

Sometimes he even misses those times with Mayura.

And Mayura is right here.

She's not lost.

And that of course is the problem.

Voices emanate from Nathalie's bedroom stopping Gabriel in his tracks outside her room. She's not one to watch videos on speaker, preferring to use her headphones to avoid disturbing them. And moreover he's sure one of those voices is Nathalie.

Only…the other voice sounds like it's in the room too and it also sounds like Nathalie. Mostly.

"I'm the one who can help him."

"You're the one who got us stuck in this bed. I can't just transform whenever anymore. Maybe you should have thought of that before breaking the Miraculous more."

Whatever's binding him here seems to both loosen and tighten. Nathalie and Mayura talking to each other, because who else would Nathalie say that to?

It feels like a dream as he wonders what he'd see inside. Mayura given a body of her own, with her hand on the wrist of a Nathalie whole and complete. Or Emilie woken from her sleep by a Nathalie desperate to push that parasite back to her first host?

"You know that wasn't my aim." One of them hisses.

"I know you got greedy. You could have waited and you'd have had Emilie."

His hand twitches. It's only what he'd thought a moment ago, but to hear Nathalie, Nathalie who he's implicitly trusted since Tibet, trusted when he didn't trust Emilie, talk as if that would have been acceptable makes him suddenly dizzy. Lightheaded with rage, as his blood starts to rush for a fight.

Gabriel forces himself to take a deep breath. Nathalie is not herself. That's why this conversation is happening. Mayura had turned Emilie from someone who thought you could get things from people by being nice to them, to something who blackmailed people in the most horrific ways and with the most perverse images.

That it might cause Nathalie to regret the possible loss of her life is nothing compared to that. This has been as hard on her as on him. He's seen the pill bottles in her room which aren't for any purely physical ailment. Despite that he knows he has her loyalty, their bond has been forged over the pressure of the years, and then solidified as she sent Emilie to sleep while Gabriel held her down. That remains true. He has to believe that.

Clearly annoyed, Mayura snaps back and Gabriel can imagine the pout on her lips, "you don't understand."

"You're right. I don't. You know that. But," Nathalie, he's sure this speaker is Nathalie sighs, "I do understand love. And we do have at least one person in common there."

Adrien of course.

The reminder of his son and how he's depending on Gabriel to bring back his mother, the mother he was always supposed to have pushes him to finally open the door ready to confront-

Nathalie.

By herself.

Standing in front of her mirror.

Discomfited, he tries to cover his confusion with, “should you be standing?”

Nathalie spins round so fast she loses her balance and stumbles and he has to run to catch her.

“Probably not,” she concedes with a weary smile.

Like Hawk Moth with Mayura he carefully lifts her up in his arms carrying her back to the bed, “what were you doing?”

“I-“ her eyes dart sideways, and something in his stomach squirms to see his ever-ready Nathalie too off balance and worn out to have a lie prepared.

“Please tell me you weren’t transforming into her and back to yourself constantly.”

“No,” Nathalie shuts her eyes as he carefully places her onto the bed, “I don’t need to do that anymore. She’s in me now even when I’m just me.”

“Nathalie,” he sighs leaning down and brushing her hair off her face.

“It’s okay.”

“It’s not ok,” he disagrees as he lies down beside her. “You’re not using that Miraculous now, so I’ll take it away and-“

“Gabriel,” she interrupts, “it’s too late for that. It’s better…better to let it be like this. If I’m not fighting she won’t push me to transform. It’s not to her advantage if I die either. This way we, we can negotiate. Like you tried.”

He swallows, “hopefully not quite like I did.”

A blush flows up Nathalie’s face, “ah, no. Not quite like that. I don’t, we. Oh I don’t need to say it.”

Gabriel spares her the need to expand, “did she and Emilie…”

Nathalie’s eyes widen, “did she and Emilie,”

“Talk.” He rushes to clarify, “like you were.”

Emilie had never been lucid about it like this. Had never admitted to awareness of any of this until far too late. But then he and Nathalie have always shared their truths with each other, the admittances wrung out of them when they’d thought they were dying, never quite letting them build their walls back up. While he’d been scheming behind Emilie’s back to manage her for years. Perhaps she’d done the same, whichever of them had shattered their trust first. Perhaps that was the difference. Perhaps it wasn’t Mayura. Perhaps it was Emilie all along.

Nathalie frowns, and he can almost see her brain working behind her eyes. “I don’t think so?”

“You don’t sound sure.”

“I remember more and more of what Mayura does, even when I think I’m the one in charge but I don’t think I get Emilie’s sense of it, and I still don’t know everything. But now. I don’t think so. Emilie, Emilie wasn’t aware of this the way I am. I walked into this with my eyes open knowing Mayura. Emilie didn’t.”

He entwines his fingers in hers, “if we ever get a chance to swipe the Rabbit I’m going to go back and destroy every bit of research there is on the Miraculous.”

“Thank you.” She mumbles, but she still seems forlorn.

Comfort is something alien to him. Emilie rarely needed it from him until the end, so certain and confident in everything. And she could always prevent Adrien from needing it, if she didn’t feel like handling herself in a more traditional way.

So he tries for distraction instead. Nathalie’s always been one to bury herself in work, in the challenge.

“Do you know what she wants?” He asks, “What she was trying to do with that brooch?”

Nathalie’s eyes are sad, “She wants to exist. I think she was trying to more permanently make Emilie look like her by changing her physical body but obviously that didn’t work out so well.”

The shadows below her cheekbone make it look sharper than it used to, but now he finds himself studying her face. Trying to work out if it is just the shadow. Trying to remember if the roots of Emilie’s highlighted hair are darker now than they’d once been.

“She does realise being blue would be a little unpractical does she not?” He attempts to, well, he’s not sure if it’s a joke or not.

“I think she could leave that if she got the rest,” Nathalie rolls over onto her back, “maybe I should cut my hair to appease her. Get laser eye surgery. Sort out a timeshare of my body.”

“You sound like you don’t expect me to win.”

“That’s not what I meant. You will win Gabriel. I believe in you, and I’m with you to the end.”

Or, rather, until she’s no longer Nathalie part of his brain reminds him.

Emilie’s sleeping figure seems to judge him as if somewhere under those closed eyelids her eyes themselves still stare at him in fear and horror.

“This was necessary,” he tells her.

The words echo around the cavernous space seeming twisted by the time they come back to his ears. He’d wanted to save Emilie and put an end to Mayura.

Instead he’s frozen Emilie in time below his house and Mayura still walks in the world above.

He wonders what would happen if he let Emilie out now. Would she stumble out on unsteady legs, unwell and needing to take to her bed but free of Mayura now that damned demoness has planted herself in Nathalie instead?

Could he abandon Nathalie to free his wife?

Or would Mayura climb out of that pod and leave him Nathalie herself again and more physically hale, to help him fight Ladybug and Chat Noir?

Or would he be left with Mayura in duplicate, both rushing to their deaths in their attempts to give her existence?

The thought makes him unwell.

It makes him the worst type of husband but even if he was sure that Nathalie’s battle with Mayura would mean Emilie could be free he’s no longer quite sure he’s brave enough for that. He’s relied on Nathalie for longer than he’s treated his beloved wife as an equal partner by now.

Gabriel can talk to Nathalie at any time. She’s always there, ready to take a call, even when she answers blearily startled from her sleep.

But it’s not the same.

Her empty chair is a yearning void in the corner of his office.

Throughout all of it, from the moment Emilie took it into her head to go after these Miraculous Nathalie has been his constant support.

And now he doesn’t know if he can trust her.

He doesn’t know who’s answering if he calls.

Nooroo curls round Duusu in what Gabriel can only think is an attempt at defence. Fair enough he supposes after what those accursed kwamis have done to him. If it wasn’t for the

fact that his fingers would phase through Duusu he'd take wrap his fingers round the kwami's body and squeeze until the bulbous head falls off.

Duusu whimpers, and he hopes his thoughts are why.

With those irritating imploring eyes Nooroo, looks up at him. "It's not Duusu's fault master, it's"

"I don't remember," Duusu starts bawling "why don't I remember?"

For once they have his attention, "she takes from you too?"

"Duusu wasn't always like this," Nooroo seems to wilt, and doesn't have to explain his meaning, Gabriel's seen the spaciness, the over-emotionality, he'd just thought it was how the Kwami was. "the things she used to create I, You need to fix the Peacock Miraculous master."

"Do you think I'm not aware of that," Gabriel snaps. "I've looked. Nathalie's looked. We have for years. If that knowledge ever existed in the world it's been lost."

"You could ask the Guardian?"

"After what I've done?" The city thinks him a villain, some supercilious moraliser will hardly help now, "after Adrien?" Would the man even left his son live or call him an abomination?, "After what Emilie did?" He's seen the photos and videos she'd kept on people. Ones that make even him ill, and in which he doesn't know who's the sentimonster and who's real in a way that makes it impossible to meet the eyes of the people he'd once called friends and acquaintances.

He'd burnt what he'd found of himself. He couldn't have such things in his house. But they'd been oddly tame given Emilie's threats. An affair with his assistant was tawdry but hardly ground-breaking. It's another reason no one could enter the house. The fear of there being something worse hidden they might stumble upon.

Nooroo leaves Duusu and flutters in front of his eyes, "it's the job of the Guardians to care for the Miraculous Jewels. He has to fix it. If his vows bind him at all then he has no choice not too."

It's obvious Nooroo means what he's saying. His Kwami isn't stupid enough to lie to him much as he clearly disagrees with Gabriel's actions, lacking the spine to do what's necessary.

And Gabriel would like to accept the offer. Would like to take the easy route for once except.

"But he has no reason to save Nathalie and Emilie," Nooroo quails back from him, "does he?"

"If it was repaired then,"

"We can't know that's enough. Not now." Gabriel can't fail them after all he's done for them.

Gabriel means to send Adrien away from Nathalie. He doesn't think the boy's presence is good for her mental state. There's nothing like the boy she views as her son to bring Mayura out. But sometimes when he finds his son, sat next to her on her bed, while she expands on whatever bit of history he's learning about in school he doesn't quite have the heart to.

He hates Mayura. But. She does love Adrien. It seems a safe outlet for her, and it makes Adrien happy without Gabriel having to force him to be. Something he's not sure he knows how to when he can't remember being happy himself.

Right now he regrets this decision.

"She what?"

Adrien cringes in front of him, "referred to her husband. She's never been married has she?"

"No," Gabriel pinches at the bridge of his nose, "no. It's her illness. She gets a little confused."

"Right." Adrien's nose scrunches up, "I kind of thought she was talking about you, she was talking about you earlier, but then she said she was so excited for me to meet him properly so apparently no but,"

"Adrien, there's nothing romantic between myself and Nathalie," Gabriel stops him automatically. "perhaps it's best you stay away from Nathalie until she's feeling better."

The uneasiness in his stomach that his son's words spark lasts all day though.

Mayura has always acted as if he's her husband. But Adrien hardly needs to meet him. So who on earth is she talking about?

Adrien's out of the house so he doesn't hesitate to transform in Nathalie's room.

Regardless of whether it's Nathalie or Mayura by his side she's always so unfailingly encouraging. Given him little smiles. Complimenting his akumas. Suggesting further plans.

She laughs at one of his comebacks to Ladybug once, and it makes him feel warm. Nathalie has been such a dark pool of despair to the magic emanating from his chest even as she's tried to keep up a determined front, and Mayura is many many different things but light has never been one of them, or at least not since he still thought she was Emilie and maybe she did too.

It's nice to see them smile not smirk, and he can't help but grin back.

Perhaps it's only the facsimile of partnership while the woman he trusts fades away for one with her own motives, but it's still the only thing that gets him through this day.

They both care for him. That much is true. So while he knows he's married, and he knows it would be beyond wrong to use Nathalie's body like Mayura's still in his wife's he doesn't attempt to stop her as she runs her hand through his hair while he sits by her from his debrief.

It's mostly Nathalie anyway he thinks. Nathalie seeing where things went wrong. Nathalie coming up with ingenious plans that might let them win.

That has to be Nathalie.

Right?

Adrien sits obediently silent on the car journey. Typical Bourgeois nonsense having the event out of Paris, but Nathalie had hacked the guest list and there's a man there they've dealt with before when trading for secrets about the Miraculous.

Usually of course Nathalie would handle all of this but he can hardly send her in his current state either physically or mentally.

However Adrien will be distraction enough for those who want to talk. Talking about his son tends to distract people from other things, and its good training for Adrien too. They'd wanted him to have Emilie's gregariousness much as he fears that Mayura might have put her own personality in there instead. Not that she's shy either.

The glow of Adrien's phone illuminates his sons face as Adrien watches whatever he looks at intently.

"I'm guessing that's not educational," Gabriel says dryly.

Adrien takes out an earbud with the slightest flush to his cheeks, "It's sort of a good idea to try and stay updated on the heroes of Paris isn't it? Only so I know how to avoid them of course. I'm not going to try and impress Ladybug or anything stupid like that. That would be ridiculous."

There's a strain to Adrien's smile that sets Gabriel on edge. One of them having to deal with the Miraculous, and a lady wearing a Miraculous is quite enough.

Though at this point he'll take any input that might help him, "anything interesting?"

"Just about Mayura's disappearance," his heart stops, "it's strange isn't it? Maybe she and Hawk Moth got divorced."

Carefully ignoring that can of worms Gabriel carefully says, "Whatever her reasons I suppose her absence is a good thing."

Adrien smiles, almost seeming nervous for some reason, "One fowl villain down then?"

The corner of his mouth tips up without permission, "what a pea-ty for Hawk Moth."

His son grins, "that was terrible."

"It was rather, wasn't it?" He smiles back and then both of them are laughing, and throwing worse and worse ones back at each other.

The journey is the closest he's felt to his son in years. The first time they've seemed to have anything in common for even longer.

Turns out Hawk Moth's colourful turns of phrase are actually good for something.

Her eyes glow with encouragement, "the user sets the limits Hawk Moth. You can do this."

He tries. It feels like electricity shooting through his chest. But it works.

Ladybug's charm fails.

Hawk Moth moves a step ahead of their enemies.

Nathalie cheers him on.

His eyes are heavy as he sits down next to Nathalie, and despite him not intending it at all he begins to doze off against her headboard.

She must think he's asleep as her lips brush over his forehead. "Sleep for now darling. We'll be together again soon."

Her hand covers his Miraculous, comfortably warm against his skin.

"Nathalie no," he mumbles, "remember who you are."

"Just for a little longer," she's warm and filling the void by his side.

"For as long as you can."

Her lips trail across his forehead again, "I'm with you to the end remember?"

Knowing Adrien is so heartbroken almost brings him to his knees. He has failed as a parent. Failed in his promises to Emilie. Failed to keep his son happy and satisfied when he's literally had the power to keep him sanguine and satisfied all this time.

That's neglect of duty isn't it?

Emilie. Nathalie. Mayura. They'd all be disappointed in him.

So he does his best to push against his usual instincts, to put aside the laser-focus on the Miraculous that's kept him steady to try to be more open.

"Adrien, since your mother disappeared, I must've been distant, but," he swallows and wishes Adrien's mother was here, "I want you to know that, if you needed to, you could," it would be easier to use the ring but now he has the chance he thinks he understands why Emilie didn't, "talk to me."

“I’m fine father,” Adrien rebuffs him.

“Good, that’s good.”

Adrien pauses at the door, “is purple the new season colour?”

“What?”

Adrien gestures at him and it’s only then Gabriel notices todays trousers are a wine-dark purple rather than red.

“I haven’t decided.” Gruffly he deflects despite his rising unease.

That gains him a scrunched up face from his son. “It’s a little bit too Hawk Moth isn’t it?”

“I hadn’t noticed,” but Adrien’s right and he wonders how he didn’t notice it before, “probably best to stay away from it then.”

Once Adrien disappears he goes upstairs and changes his clothes, flinging them to the floor as if he can destroy them if he throws them hard enough.

They lie there on the floor mocking him.

He must have bought them long before anything he’d ever known to fear the Miraculous.

His skin prickles and he almost expects to see his hands encased in leather.

Gabriel takes a shower as if Hawk Moth’s stain is something so easy to wash off.

“I don’t know if I can do it.”

Nathalie looks up at him through the tablet screen with such devotion, “You can. You know that Hawk Moth. They’re nothing stopping you but yourself.”

“Your research tells you this?”

“I know it’s the case.”

Her trust in him is heady. He feels less like her friend or her employer than her god with the pure worship in her gaze

With that behind him he can do anything.

So he akumatises a whole family In one go and ignores the agony of how his sternum seems to crack in his chest.

When he checks later he’s just fine. Not a bruise or anything to show for the pain.

His eyes are a little bloodshot in the mirror though. It almost gives his irises a purple cast. Nathalie’s right. He really does need to sleep more.

Gabriel pushes open the door to Adrien's room. "What on earth are you doing?"

He'd thought the room was soundproofed but apparently not from the thuds he discovered echoing down when he went to get a coffee in the kitchen below.

"I'm," Adrien's hand sheepishly reaches behind his neck, "practising?"

Looking at the stick in Adrien's hand he points out, "you have fencing foils."

"Not on the street? Where there might be an akuma?"

Rolling his eyes he holds his hand out, "alright then. Show me what you've got."

It's a long time since Gabriel's fenced, and months since he's practised fighting now Nathalie isn't around to spar with, but his time as Hawk Moth comes through thankfully.

It's almost like he's fought Adrien like this before.

"Hawk Moth," she gasps underneath him.

Always Hawk Moth, with every exhalation he forces out of her with his lips against her skin, with every exclamation from his hands on her, always Hawk Moth.

He kisses her to shut her up.

When he'd came in he hadn't meant to kiss her at all. His blood had been high in his anger from his latest defeat only to subside under her touch. But it had only been banked, not damped, and when she'd taken his face in her hands he hadn't stopped her. Overcome by a desire for the closeness he'd been missing.

It had felt right.

Even the name doesn't feel as wrong as it should.

She'd not taken his shirt off.

That feels important now as it sparks in a way that looks oh-too-familiar as he lies next to his wife.

Or.

Not his wife.

Hawk Moth's wife.

Al those little hints, why Mayura would encourage him on a quest which would end her existence.

It had never been about Gabriel at all.

No. It had been about giving Hawk Moth time to manifest.

He wonders if Ladybug and Chat Noir feel it too. If they have other selves taking over the more they have to wear the Miraculous to fight him. If Ladybug is as confident when she isn't Ladybug. If Chat Noir jokes so much when he isn't Chat Noir.

Perhaps it's no danger to them.

They don't have a partner pushing them to push beyond their limits and speeding it up. Or maybe they do. Maybe Ladybug's little shielding charms were as dangerous to her as breaking them was for him.

He pulls Nathalie's body close, hoping that he won't wake Mayura.

"I'm sorry." He whispers into her hair, letting it dry her tears.

With tonight, with how she'd encouraged him to his destruction he knows Nathalie, trustworthy faithful Nathalie was gone.

Had Mayura deemed Nathalie more suited to her purposes than Emilie? Is Nathalie closer to the platonic image of her? Was it just the deeper rents in the Miraculous?

His hands should move down to her neck and stop this right here. He should wake up in the morning and pretend everything's fine and then order the same drugs he used for Emilie.

She and Nathalie might fit in that casket together, just about.

But he can't.

Instead he sobs.

Maybe it's Hawk Moth's love for Mayura that stays his hand.

Maybe it's Gabriel's affection for Nathalie.

Whichever it is it's not enough to make him stay once the tear tracks on his face dry.

It's tempting, so tempting, to let himself be consumed by Hawk Moth. To shuck all this responsibility. To have a partner again, a loving destined wife. To have-

And Adrien would still be their son. He's certainly Mayura's, and it seems as if he like Hawk Moth's personality more than Gabriel's.

But Gabriel pulled himself up from mediocracy and having just-enough on bloody fingers. He made his own name one recognised worldwide. He put his new wife, and then son front and centre of the empire he made.

Beguiling as this life here, with her, is he’s not willing to disappear into nothing for another man to take his place.

He forces himself leave the bed.

To leave the woman occupying a corner of his heart that’s no longer his.

“I need your help.”

The heroes look down on him like blank arbiters of justice, like Marianne and some great man of the revolution ready to give his love Gabriel’s head.

“Forgive me if this feels like a trick.” Ladybug says, guardedly and dismissively but not, if he’s reading her right, wholly unwilling to listen.

“I think Mayura’s trying to kill me.”

Like a chorus the heroes echo together, “Wait, what?”

He sighs and steels himself. It’s a tawdry tale and an embarrassing one. Especially in front of these two who look at him like he's dirt under their shoes.

They won’t agree with all he's done. They won't understand his reasons. They’ll condemn him and it’ll take painstaking work to keep his public image intact, to keep himself out of prison.

But they’re his only chance.

Chapter End Notes

I did consider giving Hawk Moth and Mayura their happy ending but I was asked to give Gabriel a chance. So here it is. His chance.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!